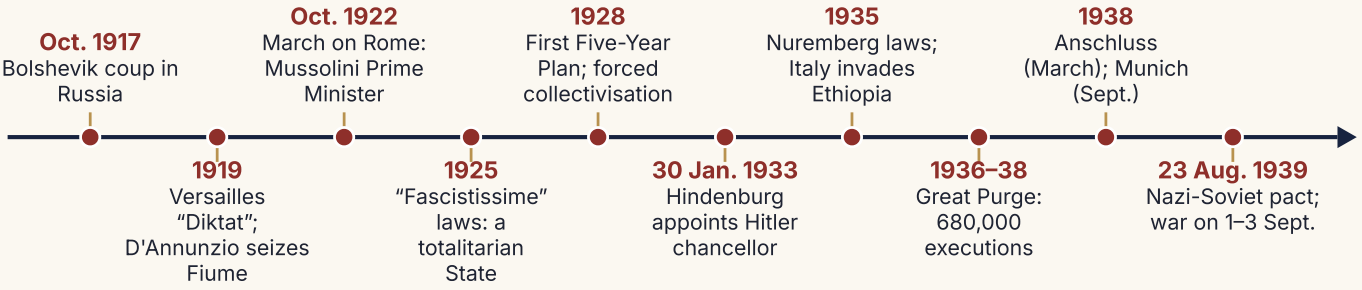
DNL HISTORY-GEOGRAPHY · TERMINALE BFI · M. ROS

H2 Totalitarian Regimes

Theme 1 — The fragilisation of democracy, totalitarianism and WWII (1929–1945)

Objective. Explain where Fascism, Nazism and Stalinism came from, how each seized power, and what made each of them specific — the groundwork for judging, in Part III, how far totalitarian ideology caused the Second World War.

Ten dates to know



The big picture

Two photographs frame the chapter: Ypres destroyed by German shells in 1917, Hiroshima destroyed by an atomic bomb in 1945. Between them, three regimes set out to control not only the State but the whole of society, and to remake human beings according to an ideology — the nation in Mussolini's Italy, the race in Hitler's Germany, the class in Stalin's USSR. Each was born from the overthrow of a democratic framework, grew out of the First World War and its violence, and drew on the confidence of millions, not only on terror. The chapter compares them column by column, as M. Ros's synthesis grid does, before asking in Part III whether their ideologies made war inevitable.

KEY ISSUES

- Assess the role of totalitarianism in the collapse of global peace in the late 1930s.

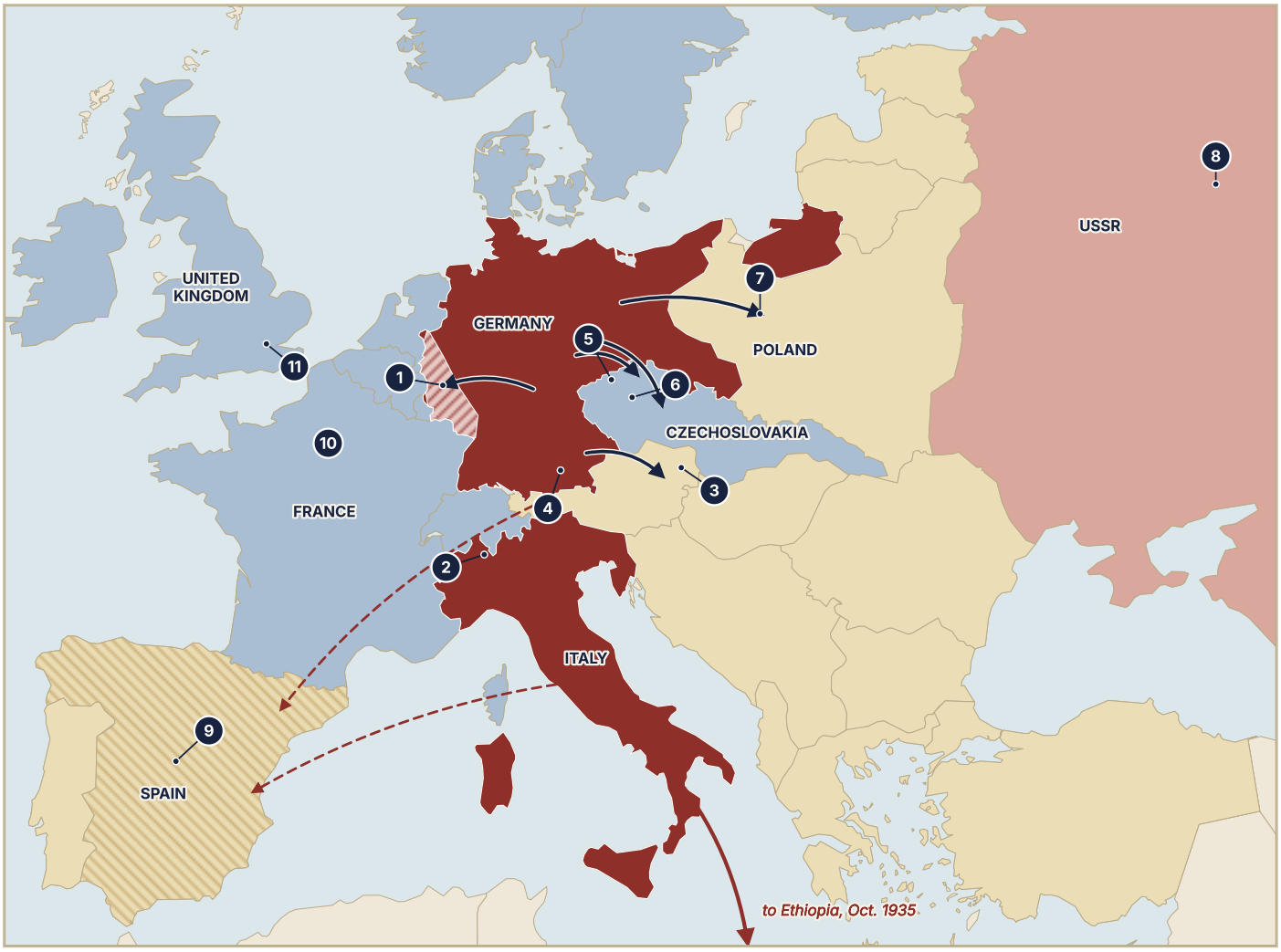
KEY TERMS

Appeasement · Totalitarianism

Summary diagram — Three regimes compared: one totalitarian method, three supreme goals

	Fascist Italy (1922–43)	Nazi Germany (1933–45)	Stalin's USSR (1924–53)
Supreme goal	The nation and the State; the glory of Rome	The race: purity and domination	A classless society
Road to power	March on Rome (Oct. 1922): appointed by the king	Appointed by Hindenburg, 30 Jan. 1933	Bolshevik coup (1917), civil war
Leader	Il Duce	Der Führer	"Little father of the peoples"
Political police	OVRA (1927), Special Court (1926)	Gestapo and SS, both under Himmler	OGPU, then NKVD (1934)
Enemy of the nation	"Enemies of the State"	Jews, Roma, disabled people…	Kulaks, "class enemies"
Youth	Opera Nazionale Balilla (1926)	Hitler Youth, compulsory in 1936	Komsomol (1918)
Terror	Confino on islands; "less oppressive?"	Dachau (1933), sterilisation, T4 (1939)	Gulag, Great Purge (680,000 executed)
Expansion	Libya, Ethiopia (1935): a new Roman empire	Lebensraum in the East (Mein Kampf)	Pact with Hitler: share of Poland (1939)

Summary map — Europe of regimes and the road to war (1935–1939)



- Fascist regimes: Germany, Italy
- USSR: communist totalitarian regime
- Democracies
- Other authoritarian regimes
- Spain: civil war, 1936–39
- Rhineland, demilitarised in 1919 (simplified)

1. Rhineland, 7 Mar. 1936: reoccupied; France and Britain do not react.
2. Stresa, Apr. 1935: Britain, France and Italy against German ambitions; the front soon collapses.
3. Vienna, 12 Mar. 1938: Anschluss; a plebiscite gives 99% “yes”, opponents and Jews excluded.
4. Munich, 29–30 Sept. 1938: Hitler, Chamberlain, Daladier and Mussolini; the Czechs are not invited.
5. Sudetenland: about 3 million German speakers, ceded to Germany.
6. Prague, 15 Mar. 1939: the rest of Czechoslovakia occupied; appeasement ends.
7. Poland, 1 Sept. 1939: invaded; France and Britain declare war on 3 Sept.
8. Moscow, 23 Aug. 1939: Nazi-Soviet pact, secret division of Poland.
9. Spain, 1936–39: Germany and Italy back Franco; France and Britain stay out.
10. Paris: Daladier signs at Munich; France puts its own economy first.
11. London: Chamberlain, prime minister from 1937, architect of appeasement.

Borders of 1930, before the Anschluss. Dark arrows: German expansion, 1936–39; dashed: German and Italian intervention in Spain. Off the map: Manchuria (1931), China (1937).

Intro Defining totalitarianism: a debate and a definition

1929 opened two crises at once — the crisis of capitalism and the threat of totalitarianism — and the chapter asks which led to war

M. Ros's introduction sets two roads side by side, both starting in 1929 and both ending in the Second World War: the crisis of capitalism studied in chapter 1, and the threat of totalitarianism studied here. The question on the slide is "and/or?": did one cause the war, or did they work together? The world crisis of the 1930s was at once a crisis of democracy in retreat and the steady advance of totalitarianism.

> **EXAMPLE** Two photographs from the same year open the chapter: a solemn crowd outside the New York Stock Exchange after the crash of 1929, and Adolf Hitler greeting supporters at the fourth Nazi Party Congress in Nuremberg, also in 1929.

Historians disagree about the underlying causes of the Second World War

The aim of Theme 1 is to assess the underlying causes of the war, and three historians give three answers. For A. J. P. Taylor, the war came from the failure of the democracies to stop Hitler — a thesis M. Ros calls very controversial. For Paul N. Hehn, it was an economic conflict, born of the crash and its consequences. For Jay Winter, 1914–1945 was a single "Thirty Years War", the second conflict being the direct continuation of the first. This chapter tests a further candidate: totalitarian ideology.

> **EXAMPLE** The three historians on M. Ros's slide: A. J. P. Taylor (1906–1990), Paul N. Hehn (1927–2014) and Jay Winter (born 1945). Taylor's The Origins of the Second World War (1961) is on the reading list with the warning "very controversial thesis".

Totalitarianism: a regime that seeks total control of society, through coercion, to transform man according to an ideology

The definition has three parts. Control is total: it reaches work, leisure, family, school, religion and thought, not only political life. It relies on coercion — terror and propaganda together. And its aim is not obedience but transformation: the regime wants to create a "New Man" shaped by its ideology. That last element separates a totalitarian regime from an ordinary dictatorship, which is content if people keep quiet.

> **EXAMPLE** The "Key Traits of Totalitarianism" wheel on M. Ros's slide (MacDougal Littell, World History, 2009) lists seven: an ideology, a dynamic leader, dictatorship and one-party rule, state control of individuals, state control of society, methods of enforcement (police terror, indoctrination, censorship, persecution) and modern technology.

An ideology is a set of beliefs that sets a supreme goal to be achieved

Each regime studied has its own supreme goal: a classless society for the USSR, the greatness of the nation and the State for Fascist Italy, the purity and domination of the race for Nazi Germany. Because the goal is presented as supreme, it justifies any means, including the suffering of millions. This is why ideology is the key to the chapter: it explains what these regimes did inside their borders and, in Part III, why they looked for war outside them.

> **EXAMPLE** In his speech of 7 January 1933, studied in Worksheet 2, Stalin presents the Five-Year Plan as the way to "the abolition of classes in the U.S.S.R." — in the very months when the famine of 1932–33 was killing peasants in Ukraine.

Arendt: these regimes rested on the confidence of the masses, not on terror alone

The class read Hannah Arendt's words on the slide as a warning against a black-and-white picture: large masses trusted these regimes, and not everyone felt oppressed. For Arendt, neither Hitler nor Stalin could have kept power through so many crises without that popular confidence. Understanding totalitarianism therefore means explaining support as well as terror. The epigraph on the cover sheet adds the other side: their propaganda treats facts as something power can manufacture.

> **EXAMPLE** Hannah Arendt (1906–1975), a German American political theorist, writes in The Origins of Totalitarianism (1951) that Hitler's rise "was legal in terms of majority rule" and that both dictators needed "the confidence of the masses".

Three regimes, one trajectory: born from the overthrow of a democratic framework, they paved the way to war and all ended in failure

The chapter studies three regimes side by side. They share the same totalitarian ambition but rest on opposite ideologies: the nation for Fascism, the race for Nazism, the class for Stalinism. M. Ros sums up their common path in three steps: each was born from the overthrow of a democratic framework, all paved the way to the Second World War, and all ended in failure.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros's slide dates the three regimes: Stalin's USSR (1924–1953), Mussolini's Fascist Italy (1922–1943) and Nazi Germany (1933–1945), each shown with its flag — hammer and sickle, fascist eagle, swastika.

I.1 The legacy of WW1

Brutalisation: the war made violence ordinary, and the totalitarian regimes were born in the trenches

The historian George Mosse coined the term brutalisation: four years of mass killing accustomed soldiers to violence, and after 1918 they brought it back into civilian life and politics. The traumas of the war therefore raised the level of violence in post-war societies. For Mosse, the First World War is the "matrix of totalitarianism": the uniforms, ranks, parades and contempt for human life of the new regimes all come from the front.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros illustrates it with a photograph of Adolf Hitler as a soldier in 1915, sitting among his comrades. George Mosse (1918–1999), a German-American historian, develops the idea in Fallen Soldiers: Reshaping the Memory of the World Wars.

Russia: the war brought down the Tsar, and the Bolsheviks seized power and imposed their rule by civil war

Russia's situation is a Première recap — not covered in class last year but on the programme (see the Première recaps on the site). In February 1917 a revolution forced the Tsar to abdicate. In October the Bolsheviks led by Lenin and Trotsky carried out what M. Ros calls a communist coup, supported by the soviets, the workers' councils in factories and the countryside. They signed peace with Germany, then won a civil war against the Whites with the Red Army, until 1922. Their Marxism meant the end of private property — and it frightened Europe.

> **EXAMPLE** The USSR was created in 1922 and its impact on Europe was huge: the Red Scare. M. Ros's slide shows Lenin's speech in Petrograd to workers, soldiers and sailors on 3 (16) April 1917, and the Petrograd Soviet in session.

Italy: a "mutilated victory" fed an irredentist nationalism, in a country shaken by turmoil, inflation and mass unemployment

At the end of the war Italy did not get all the lands it had been promised. The result was an irredentist movement, demanding the "unredeemed" territories, and nationalists spoke of a "mutilated victory": the country had won and paid in blood, yet felt cheated. The frustration came on top of social turmoil, inflation and mass unemployment, and gave post-war Italy its first taste of nationalist violence.

> **EXAMPLE** The class noted Fiume among the frustrations: in September 1919 the poet Gabriele D'Annunzio seized the city with nationalist volunteers and held it until December 1920 — rituals later borrowed by Mussolini.

The Biennio Rosso (1919–1920): the fear of a communist revolution was real, and the Blackshirts repressed it for the landowners

In the "red years" of 1919–1920, peasants seized land and workers went on strike or took over the factories. Property owners believed an Italian 1917 was coming, and the fear of a communist revolution was real. Mussolini's Blackshirts, the fascist militia, answered with violent repression of the strikers; landowners paid them to take back the properties that landless farmers had seized. Fascism grew as the armed wing of the frightened propertied classes.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros's slide shows the general strike of 1920 in Turin, when workers occupied and ran the factories themselves as part of an attempt to build a socialist society.

Germany: military defeat ended the Empire, and the Weimar Republic was born in civil violence

In 1918 military defeat brought the demise of the German Empire and the establishment of the Weimar Republic. In the cities, revolutionaries tried to go further: the Spartacist uprising of 1919, a communist revolt led by Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht, attempted a revolution on the Russian model and failed. From its first weeks the republic was associated with defeat and with bloodshed on both sides.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros's slide shows a barricade during the Spartacist uprising of 1919. Luxemburg and Liebknecht were murdered by Freikorps soldiers on 15 January 1919.

Germany: the Versailles "Diktat" humiliated the nation, and military circles spread the stab-in-the-back conspiracy theory

The Treaty of Versailles (1919) was imposed, not negotiated — Germany would be invaded if it refused to sign. It contained the War Guilt Clause, took Alsace-Lorraine and the eastern territories, and imposed huge reparations: the Germans called it a "Diktat". At the same time military circles spread the stab-in-the-back conspiracy theory: the army had not been beaten at the front but betrayed at home. The myth turned defeat into a grievance and gave the far right its enemies ready-made.

> **EXAMPLE** A German postcard of 1919 on M. Ros's slide shows a soldier stabbed from behind by a caricatured Jew: the myth blamed democrats, pacifists, socialists or, as here, Jews.

Germany: a first failed coup in 1923, then the extreme economic crisis of the 1930s

The Weimar Republic never won over its enemies. In 1923 Hitler tried to seize power by force in Munich and failed; he drew the lesson that power had to be won through the institutions. Then, in the 1930s, the extreme economic crisis studied in chapter 1 gave his party the mass audience it had lacked. The war created the grievances; the crisis turned them into votes.

> **EXAMPLE** Hitler's failed coup took place in Munich in November 1923; imprisoned afterwards, he wrote Mein Kampf, where, as M. Ros's slides note, he exposed his racist views as early as 1924–1925.

I.2 The seizure of power

Mussolini's fascism combined a growing party, one leader, a "Law and Order" programme, a Roman symbol and paramilitary squads

M. Ros breaks fascism down into its components. A party with a growing influence and an increasing number of supporters, and one leader. A programme that appealed to voters: "Law and Order". A symbol: the word fascist refers to an ancient imperial Roman artefact, the fasces. And paramilitary fascist squad leaders. The programme spoke directly to landowners and shopkeepers terrified by communism after the Biennio Rosso, who supported fascism for that reason.

> **EXAMPLE** The fasces — a bundle of rods around an axe, carried before Roman magistrates — gave the movement its name and its emblem; the class notes record that landowners and shopkeepers, terrified by communism, supported fascism.

Mussolini came to power by intimidation rather than by a coup: the threat of violence forced a legal appointment

In October 1922 the Blackshirts marched on Rome. Mussolini organised the march to push the king into appointing him Prime Minister, not to take power by arms. Only a few thousand came — about 20,000 according to the class, far fewer than he hoped. Most of the Blackshirts were suspected of murder, and though they were not violent during the march itself, everyone knew they could be. The threat was enough: the king appointed Mussolini.

> **EXAMPLE** The March on Rome, dated 22 to 29 October 1922 on M. Ros's slide: Mussolini surrounded by the squad leaders Emilio De Bono, Italo Balbo and Cesare Maria De Vecchi. King Victor Emmanuel III refused martial law and appointed Mussolini Prime Minister on 30 October.

Hitler's Nazism had the same components, with a programme drawn from Mein Kampf

Like fascism, Nazism had a party with a growing influence and one leader, a symbol and paramilitary organisations. Its programme, based on Mein Kampf, planned to abolish the Treaty of Versailles, to unite Germany and Austria, to nationalise large industries and businesses, and to exclude Jews from German society. Its symbol was the black swastika, which the Nazis considered an "Aryan" symbol; its paramilitary organisations were the SA and the SS.

> **EXAMPLE** The swastika was an ancient and widespread sign, long seen as lucky — which is why, as the class noted, nothing seemed sinister in choosing it; the Nazis made it "Aryan". Hitler greeting his supporters at the fourth Nazi Party Congress, Nuremberg 1929, shows the party already staged as a movement.

Nazism conquered the street through paramilitary violence: the SA as a mass force, the SS as an elite

The Nazi movement had two armed wings. The SA (storm troopers) were a mass force, largely recruited among unemployed and uneducated men, some with criminal records, who fought communists in the streets and protected Nazi meetings. The SS was an elite: selected, better educated, often from wealthier backgrounds. Violence was not a side effect of Nazism but one of its tools of conquest.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** By 1933 the SA counted several hundred thousand men — several times the 100,000-man army that the Treaty of Versailles allowed Germany. (Order of magnitude added from outside the course.)

The crisis turned the Nazis from a fringe party into the first party of Germany — without ever giving them a majority

Unemployment and the Nazi vote rose together. In 1928, before the crisis, the NSDAP was a fringe party; by July 1932, with millions unemployed, it had become the largest party in the Reichstag. But it never won a majority in a free election, and it even lost ground in November 1932. Hitler did not come to power because a majority of Germans voted for him.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros's charts: German unemployment rose to about 5.6 million in 1932, and the NSDAP vote went from 2.6% (May 1928) to 18.3% (September 1930), 37.4% (July 1932) and 33.1% (November 1932). The photograph shows unemployed men queuing for food aid in Hanover in 1932.

Conservative elites handed power to Hitler legally, convinced they could control him

Like Mussolini, Hitler did not take power by a coup: he was appointed Chancellor by the President of the Republic, Paul von Hindenburg, on 30 January 1933. Hindenburg was an old general of the Empire who had supported the monarchy. The conservatives around him thought they could control Hitler once he was in government. The legal façade reassured the elites while the Nazis prepared to dismantle the republic from inside.

> **EXAMPLE** The photograph that opens M. Ros's section: recently appointed as chancellor, Hitler bows to greet President Hindenburg at Potsdam on 21 March 1933 — an image designed to present Nazism as the heir of the old Prussian order.

The new regime used an emergency to suspend freedoms and crush the communists

A month after Hitler's appointment, the German Parliament, the Reichstag, was set on fire. The Nazis immediately blamed the communists and presented the fire as the signal of a revolution. Hitler and Hindenburg used it to decide to rise against communism: civil liberties were suspended and communists were hunted down. Who really started the fire is still debated today — possibly the Nazis themselves. What matters is how the regime used it.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The fire broke out on 27 February 1933; the next day Hindenburg signed a decree suspending freedom of the press, of assembly and of opinion, and thousands of communists were arrested within days. (Dates of the decree added from outside the course.)

I.3 Specific aspects of each regime

Fascism: a “new revolution” meant to transform civilisation and recreate the glory of Rome

Fascism presented itself as a new revolution, neither liberal nor socialist. Its aim was to transform Italian civilisation and to recreate the greatness of ancient Rome. Mussolini wanted a disciplined, warlike people united behind the State. The ambition was total: history itself was to start again with fascism.

> **EXAMPLE** The poster of the Mostra della Rivoluzione Fascista (Rome, 1932) on M. Ros's slide is dated “year XI”: the Fascist calendar starts with the year of Mussolini's seizure of power, 1922.

Fascism destroyed parliamentary opposition by violence, then made the dictatorship legal

Once in power, Mussolini still had to face the left. Giacomo Matteotti, a socialist deputy, criticised him openly in Parliament. He disappeared; his body was later found. Mussolini publicly endorsed the murder and claimed that Matteotti had been an enemy of peace. He then introduced the fascist laws, which turned the country into a totalitarian State. This is the end of the parliamentary monarchy: the king remained, but Parliament no longer counted.

> **EXAMPLE** Giacomo Matteotti was kidnapped on 10 June 1924 after denouncing electoral fraud and violence (M. Ros's slide dates the murder 1925, the year it bore fruit); on 3 January 1925 Mussolini claimed responsibility before the Chamber, and the 1925 “fascistissime” laws made Italy a totalitarian state.

“Totalitarian”: a word the fascists used in a positive sense

The term totalitarianism was not only a label applied later by historians: the fascists themselves used it with pride, to describe a State that swallows everything. For them, “totalitarian” meant complete, united, strong — the opposite of a divided liberal society. The word only took on its accusing meaning when historians and philosophers such as Arendt applied it to Nazism and Stalinism after the war.

> **EXAMPLE** The Doctrine of Fascism (1932), by Mussolini and the philosopher Giovanni Gentile, studied on M. Ros's slide: for the Fascist, “everything is in the State”, and “in this sense Fascism is totalitarian”.

Fascism divides society into nations, not classes: it is the opposite of Marxism

Marxism divides every society into classes locked in struggle. Fascism says the opposite: what divides humanity is nations, and inside the nation all classes must be united under the State. Class struggle is therefore banned rather than encouraged. This is why fascism attracted owners frightened by socialism: it promised national unity instead of revolution.

> **EXAMPLE** The Doctrine of Fascism (1932) declares Fascism opposed to Socialism, which “confines the movement of history within the class struggle” and ignores the unity of classes in the State.

Fascism rejects parliamentarism, liberalism and human rights: it is nationalist and militaristic

For M. Ros, Fascism is the first totalitarianism. It rejects parliamentarism, the rule of elected assemblies; it is nationalist and militaristic; it does not believe in the existence of human rights; and it is against both liberalism and Marxism. Where liberalism starts from the individual and his rights, Fascism starts from the State, which alone gives the individual his value.

> **EXAMPLE** The Doctrine of Fascism (1932) on M. Ros's slide: “Liberalism denied the State in the interests of the particular individual”, while Fascism reaffirms the State as the true reality of the individual.

Fascism's terror was less oppressive than Nazism's, and its power met a counter-power: the Church

Fascism was less oppressive than Nazism: its aim was to silence opponents, not to kill them all. Its power was also incomplete. Mussolini had to come to terms with the Pope, because he did not have enough power to take control of the Church, and the king remained head of the State. A totalitarian ambition does not always mean totalitarian control.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros asks “Less oppressive terror?” — with a question mark — and names the counter-power: the Catholic Church, with which Mussolini signed a concordat, the Lateran Accords, in 1929. Opponents were usually sent into internal exile on islands such as Lipari rather than executed.

Fascism was not racist before 1938: the turn came with the alliance with Hitler

Unlike Nazism, Italian Fascism was not founded on racism, and anti-Semitism was not part of its early programme. The shift came in 1938: allied with Hitler, Mussolini introduced anti-Semitic laws, and the nation became officially racist. Racism in Italy was thus a late turn tied to the German alliance rather than the core of the ideology — which makes it no less real for its victims.

> **EXAMPLE** La Difesa della Razza (“The Defence of the Race”), a magazine published from August 1938 on M. Ros's slide, set a Roman profile against Jewish and African faces; specialists of “race” came into schools to teach the superiority of the fascist race. Roberto Benigni's Life is Beautiful (1997) mocks this racism.

Stalinism: class struggle as the engine — the capitalist elements must be eliminated

Soviet ideology is Marxist: history is a struggle between classes, and it ends with a society without classes, private property or profit. Stalin's Five-Year Plan turned this into a programme. The USSR had to become an industrial and powerful country, independent of world capitalism, and at the same time oust the last capitalist elements — above all in the countryside, where most people still farmed their own land.

> **EXAMPLE** Stalin's speech to the Central Committee of 7 January 1933 (Worksheet 2, source 1) says the Plan had to turn a country with “backward, and in part medieval, technology” into one “fully self-reliant and independent of the caprices of world capitalism”.

Forced collectivisation: small farms were merged into large collective ones

Collectivisation meant transferring small and scattered farms into large collective ones. Independent households were suppressed and the peasants grouped in kolkhozes (collective farms) or sovkhozes (state-owned farms). The aim, according to the Plan, was the total collectivisation of the country in five years and the end of any possibility of a return to capitalism in the countryside.

> **EXAMPLE** Worksheet 2, source 2: peasant households collectivised rose from 7% in 1928 to 57% in 1930 and 90% in 1936. A Soviet poster of 1930 on M. Ros's slide calls: "Come with us to the kolkhoz, comrades!"

The kulak label turned any peasant who resisted collectivisation into a class enemy

On paper, a kulak was a peasant who owned more than 8 acres of land. In practice, the label was given to any peasant who refused collectivisation, accused of being too selfish to share. The kulaks were persecuted as a class: their land and animals were confiscated and many were deported. Their resistance was described by the regime as "kulak sabotage" to be broken.

> **EXAMPLE** M. Ros's slide shows farmers of the kolkhozes protesting against the kulaks in 1929 under a banner calling for their liquidation as a class; in Ukraine in 1932 (Werth, source 4), peasants who hid grain were accused of "kulak sabotage", whatever the size of their land.

The result: the Holodomor, the great famine of 1932–33 in Ukraine

Grain was requisitioned whatever the harvest. Peasants resisted by hiding grain in pits and secret granaries or by sending children and the elderly to cut stalks at night; the regime answered with brigades backed by the political police, the OGPU, sent to "take the grain". Molotov and Kaganovich, sent by the Politburo, first halted deliveries of manufactured goods to districts that had not fulfilled the plan; the most "rebellious" villages were then cut off from all supplies, including food. The result was a man-made famine, the Holodomor.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Nicolas Werth (source 4): in September 1932 only 32% of the monthly grain target was reached in Ukraine, and by 25 October only 22%; "rebellious" villages were "placed on the blackboard". The famine killed about four million people in Ukraine. (Death toll added from outside the class notes.)

Collectivisation also ruined Soviet agriculture: no motivation, less production

Beyond the famine, collectivisation was an economic failure. Peasants who lost their land and animals had no reason to work hard for the kolkhoz, and many slaughtered their livestock rather than hand it over. Production fell, resources became scarcer and the mood in the countryside turned hostile. The regime chose ideology and control over the food supply of its own people.

> **EXAMPLE** In a letter of 9 April 1932 from Novosibirsk (source 5), Feigin told Ordzhonikidze that kolkhoz cows gave 1 to 3 litres of milk a day instead of the normal 5 to 7, that peasants were slaughtering their last animals, and that "people are starving".

Nazism: race struggle — history as a permanent war between races

For the Nazis, the history of humankind is a struggle between races. Races form a hierarchy, some more "valuable" than others, and it is crucial to recognise and study them; the "Aryans" are the purest. Every individual shares a collective instinct for survival, and the survival of the race depends on two things: race purity — hence the ban on relations between "races" — and the seizure of territory to expand the population. Hitler set out these racist views as early as 1924–1925 in Mein Kampf.

> **EXAMPLE** A scene of public humiliation in 1935 on M. Ros's slide: a non-Jewish woman and a Jewish man, surrounded by SA men, forced to wear placards denouncing their relationship. A chart of the Nazi health ministry (Bamberg) ranked the "racial groups of the earth".

Jews described as "bacteria" infecting the nation: a biological language that prepares elimination

In Nazi ideology the Jews were the most dangerous race: unlike the others they had no living space of their own, and they supposedly sought to dominate their host peoples by destroying the nation-state, aiming at the genetic "bastardisation" of all peoples and the elimination of all states. The class noted the biological language that followed: Jews as bacteria infecting the body of the nation, a "virus" to be eliminated. If a people is a disease, eliminating it becomes hygiene rather than crime. Words prepared deeds.

> **EXAMPLE** Racial instruction became mandatory in German schools in September 1933; the children's book Der Giftpilz ("The Poisonous Mushroom", Nuremberg, 1938) and Elvira Bauer's book of 1936 ("For all the Jews must leave") carried the message to children.

Nazi racism also struck Germans judged "unfit": disabled and sick people

The list of those to be eliminated went beyond the Jews: disabled people, people with genetic diseases and anyone who had a sexual relationship with these "viruses" were targeted. The T4 programme organised the murder of disabled people in Germany itself. It shows that Nazi racism attacked Germans too when they did not fit the ideal of the pure race.

> **EXAMPLE** The T4 "euthanasia" programme, launched in 1939, murdered disabled Germans in specially built gas chambers — about 70,000 between 1939 and 1941, mostly in gas chambers, according to M. Ros's revised slides.

II.1 Cult of personality and cult of the party

The leader is built as an ideal man, the Guide, in whom the nation recognises itself

Totalitarian propaganda does not simply praise a politician: it manufactures a superior being, the Guide, whose qualities are supposed to be those the people should acquire. The leader is shown as soldier, worker, father and visionary at once, and his name is attached to the country itself. He is not presented as the head of a government that could be replaced, but as the incarnation of the nation.

> **EXAMPLE** Mussolini is “il Duce”, Hitler “der Führer”, Stalin “the little father of the peoples”, and a city was renamed Stalingrad in 1925 — Petrograd had already become Leningrad in 1924. Hubert Lanzinger painted Hitler as a knight in armour carrying the flag (The Standard Bearer, 1934–36).

Mass rallies and rituals create an emotional bond between the people and the leader

The regimes govern by staging. Rallies, parades, salutes and mottos turn political support into a collective physical experience, in which the individual feels dissolved into a disciplined crowd. The ritual is repeated until it becomes ordinary: a greeting, a gesture, a sentence learned by heart. Obedience is thus produced by emotion rather than by argument.

> **EXAMPLE** The official German greeting became “Heil Hitler” with the Nazi salute; the fascist motto held that “il Duce ha sempre ragione” — Mussolini is always right. The Nuremberg rally of 1934 was filmed by Leni Riefenstahl in Triumph of the Will. Hitler's speeches lasted three to four hours and held the crowd spellbound (class notes); the other Fascist motto noted in class was “Credere, obbedire, combattere” — believe, obey, fight.

The media and the arts are harnessed, so that propaganda reaches people at home

Propaganda works because it is everywhere. Cinema, radio, painting and sculpture are placed at the service of the regime, and new technologies are deliberately made affordable so that the leader's voice enters each household. Art is judged not by its quality but by its usefulness: it must show the ideal society as if it already existed.

> **EXAMPLE** A 1938 advertisement for the cheap Volksempfänger radio promised that “Germany listens to the Führer thanks to the people's radio”. At the 1937 Paris World Fair the Soviet pavilion, crowned by Mukhina's Worker and Kolkhoz Woman, faced the German pavilion directly. In Germany the whole machine was run by Joseph Goebbels, the propaganda specialist, with the photographs of Heinrich Hoffmann, Hitler's personal photographer, and the films of Leni Riefenstahl.

Censorship removes every criticism — and even rewrites the past

The cult only holds if nothing contradicts it. The press is controlled, criticism is punished, and in the Soviet case the archive itself is corrected: photographs are retouched to delete those who have fallen from favour. The regime does not merely forbid opposing opinions, it tries to make them unthinkable by erasing the evidence that they ever existed.

> **EXAMPLE** Nikolai Yezhov, head of the NKVD, stands beside Stalin in a photograph taken at the Moscow–Volga canal; after his execution in 1940 he simply disappears from the same image.

The purpose: to make the fate of the nation, of the party and of the leader one and the same

The cult of personality is not vanity, it is a technique of government. By identifying the nation with the party and the party with one man, the regime makes any opposition look like treason against the country itself. The leader's legitimacy then no longer depends on an election, and the whole system is protected by the emotion attached to his person.

> **EXAMPLE** Each regime condensed this identification into one symbol, adopted at the party's foundation or soon after: the Roman fasces for the Fascist Party (1921), the swastika for the NSDAP (1920), the hammer and sickle on the Soviet state emblem (1923).

The “little father of the peoples” imposed one language on a multinational Union

Stalin's cult presented him as the protective father of all the nations of the USSR. Behind the image, the father imposed one culture: although Georgian himself, Stalin made Russian the language of the whole Union, and the Georgians were pushed to study even their own texts in Russian and to speak Russian. The cult of one man went together with the forced unification of a whole empire.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** From March 1938, learning Russian became compulsory in every school of the USSR, including in the national republics such as Georgia. (Date of the 1938 decree added from outside the course.)

II.2 Total control over society and the creation of a “New Man”

Totalitarianism does not want obedient subjects, it wants to produce a new kind of human being

This is what separates a totalitarian regime from an ordinary dictatorship. A dictatorship demands that you keep quiet; a totalitarian regime demands that you change. The ideology defines a model of humanity, and the whole machinery of the state — school, leisure, work, family, law — is turned towards producing it. Private life has no protected space left.

> **EXAMPLE** Each regime had its own model: the German “New Man” was a purified race, the Volk, which led to the sterilisation law of 1933; the Soviet one was a worker, celebrated from 1935 through the miner Stakhanov; the fascist one was strong and cultured in the service of the Party.

Youth comes first, because children can be shaped before they can judge

All three regimes built compulsory or quasi-compulsory youth organisations that took over the time outside school: uniforms, camps, sport, songs and political instruction. The aim was to form the next generation directly, bypassing the family and the church, so that loyalty to the regime would be acquired before any capacity to question it.

> **EXAMPLE** Italy founded the Opera Nazionale Balilla in 1926; Germany made the Hitler Youth compulsory by the law of 1936, and it counted about 8 million members by 1939; the USSR had the Komsomol, created in 1918. Mussolini boasted: "I take men in the cradle and I do not return them to the pope until after their death." Hitler described the chain himself in 1938 (Worksheet 3, source 2): children enter at ten, four years in the Young Folk, four in the Hitler Youth, then Labour Service — and "the Wehrmacht will take care of" whatever class consciousness is left.

Thought, culture and information are controlled, and the school teaches the ideology as science

Education is not merely censored, it is rewritten. Textbooks, children's books and lessons carry the ideology in a form suitable for the youngest, and in Germany racial doctrine was taught as if it were a natural science, with charts, measurements and classifications. A child thus learns to see the enemy before ever meeting one.

> **EXAMPLE** Racial instruction became compulsory in German schools in September 1933. The antisemitic children's book Der Giftpilz ("The Poisonous Mushroom", Nuremberg, 1938) taught that "the Jewish nose is crooked, it looks like a 6".

The law itself is used to reshape society, by sorting human beings into categories

In Nazi Germany the ideology became legislation. The Nuremberg laws of 15 September 1935 forbade marriage and sexual relations between Jews and "persons of German blood", banned Jewish households from employing young German women, and forbade Jews to fly the Reich flag. The state thus defined citizenship by descent, and the administration produced the tables needed to apply it.

> **EXAMPLE** An official table of 1935 classified people by fractions of ancestry: German-blooded, Mischling of the second degree (1/4 Jewish), Mischling of the first degree (3/8 or 1/2), or Jew (3/4 or more) — the last category being refused Reich citizenship altogether.

Work, leisure and the economy are absorbed too, so that nothing stands outside the regime

Independent trade unions are dissolved, leisure organisations are created by the state, and the economy is directed towards the regime's goals — collectivisation and five-year plans in the USSR, rearmament and autarky in Germany. What remains of civil society, from sports clubs to charities, is either absorbed or suppressed, so that no organisation can mediate between the individual and the party.

> **EXAMPLE** The Soviet "New Man" had his hero in Alexei Stakhanov, a miner presented in 1935 as having cut fourteen times his quota in one shift, which gave its name to Stakhanovism and to the competitions imposed in every factory.

Three New Men for three supreme goals: race, class, nation

Worksheet 3 compares the three youth organisations. The method is the same — taking children early, uniforms, camps, ideology — but the ideal differs. The Nazis wanted strong, obedient, educated and "Aryan" children in the service of the Volk, on the basis of social Darwinism: the stronger races survive. The Soviet New Man was a well-educated worker who had studied Marx and Lenin. The Fascist New Man was ready to fight, calm and cold-blooded, nourished on Latin and Plutarch as the heir of Rome.

> **EXAMPLE** The sources of Worksheet 3: the Hitler Youth poster of 1935 ("Youth serves the Führer! All ten-year-olds into the Hitler Youth"); the programme of the Smolensk Komsomol (1919), which wants to turn young workers and peasants "into revolutionaries, into fighters for the interest of the working classes"; the 1936 photograph of the Opera Nazionale Balilla, boys in black uniforms carrying rifles.

II.3 Mass terror

Terror is not a failure of order but a method of government

In a totalitarian regime, violence is not the exceptional answer to a crisis: it is permanent, organised and planned. Hannah Arendt argued that such regimes had found "a means of dominating and terrorizing human beings from within" — the point is not only to punish, but to install fear so deeply that each person censors himself. Obedience then no longer needs to be commanded.

> **EXAMPLE** Hergé's Tintin in the Land of the Soviets (1930) already showed Western readers a police state of staged elections and hidden famine — a caricature, but one that circulated the image of terror long before the archives were open.

Each regime built a political police answering to the party, not to the courts

The instrument of terror is a police placed above the law. In the USSR the OGPU, then the NKVD, organised deportations to the labour camps; in Germany the Gestapo, the state police, and the S.S., the police of the party, were both headed by Himmler; in Italy Mussolini created the OVRA in 1927. Because these bodies answered to the leader, no judge could protect a citizen from them.

> **EXAMPLE** Himmler held both German police forces at once from 1936, after the Gestapo of 1933 was placed under his authority; the OVRA dates from 1927 and the NKVD from 1934.

Justice is turned into theatre: the Moscow show trials

Soviet terror culminated in trials staged for the public, in which old Bolsheviks confessed to crimes they had not committed, after their families had been threatened. The Great Purge of 1937–38 decimated the party and weakened the army, and it reinforced Stalin precisely because it destroyed everyone who could have replaced him. The worksheet counts 680,000 executions.

> **EXAMPLE** At his trial Zinoviev declared himself "the principal organiser of Kirov's assassination"; Kamenev said he had been "actuated by boundless hatred and by lust of power". Both had been photographed beside Stalin in 1925, together with Alexei Rykov; Stalin had all three men in that picture shot (Zinoviev and Kamenev in 1936, Rykov in 1938).

The camp becomes a permanent institution, and forced labour an economic resource

Repression is not only judicial, it is territorial: whole populations are confined. Germany opened Dachau in 1933 for everyone deemed incompatible with society, and the camps classified their prisoners by coloured triangles. The Soviet Gulag spread camps across the whole country, chosen where labour was needed — mines, timber, canals — so that terror also produced. As M. Ros put it, the Nazis did not invent the camp; what they added was the gas chamber.

EXAMPLE The White Sea–Baltic Canal, 227 km dug between 1931 and 1933 largely with hand tools, was the first great Soviet project built by Gulag prisoners, and the worksheet's graph shows the camp population passing 1.5 million in the early 1950s. In the Nazi camps a red triangle marked political prisoners, green criminals, pink homosexuals, black "anti-socials", purple Jehovah's Witnesses, with a yellow triangle added for Jews.

Nazi violence also struck Germans themselves, in the name of biology

Racial doctrine produced violence inside the German population. A law of 1933 allowed the forced sterilisation of Germans with conditions presumed hereditary, and propaganda justified it by cost: a poster compared the 5.50 Reichsmarks a day spent on one sick person with the cost of a healthy family. In 1939 the logic went further, into killing.

EXAMPLE About 400,000 people were sterilised between 1933 and 1945 for nine listed conditions, including blindness, deafness and schizophrenia; between 1939 and 1941 the doctors of the T4 "euthanasia" programme killed about 70,000 disabled Germans, mostly in gas chambers built for the purpose.

Terror turns against the regime's own men, which is what makes it total

The most revealing feature of totalitarian violence is that no one is safe, not even those who serve it. The Great Purge ended by devouring the head of the NKVD himself, and the Nazi regime had already purged its own paramilitary ranks. When loyalty no longer protects, obedience must be anticipated rather than merely given — and that is exactly the effect sought.

EXAMPLE Yezhov, Stalin's most trusted police chief, was executed in 1940 and replaced by Beria, who held the post until 1953. In Germany, the Night of the Long Knives of 1934 left 85 people murdered, among them the leadership of the S.A. Terror even reached abroad: Leon Trotsky, Stalin's most influential rival, was assassinated in Mexico in 1940 by an agent of the Soviet police.

Italian terror was real but of a different scale, which the comparison must respect

Fascist violence founded the regime and then became routine, but it never reached the scale of the other two. The murder of the socialist deputy Matteotti in 1924 was the turning point: after it Mussolini abandoned parliament and built the totalitarian state, suppressing the opposition press and excluding non-fascist ministers. The repression was then legalised rather than industrialised.

EXAMPLE The State Defence Law of 1926 restored the death penalty and set up a Special Court for the "enemies of the State"; the OVRA followed in 1927. The Special Court passed far fewer death sentences than the Soviet or German systems — hence the course's question: "less oppressive terror?" Italy had no concentration camps: opponents were sent to "confino", internal exile on remote islands.

The common logic of the three terrors: choose an enemy of the nation, and violence becomes acceptable

The task of Worksheet 4 is to find the similarities between the three regimes. All three used a secret police to threaten the population, silenced or killed their opponents and, above all, chose an enemy of the nation, so that violence against part of the population seemed justified to the rest. In Germany this rested on a conspiracy theory: the nation was supposedly undermined by enemies from within.

EXAMPLE The kulaks in the USSR (Part I, Worksheet 2); in Germany, Jews, Roma, prostitutes, homosexuals and disabled people, 400,000 of whom were forcibly sterilised (Worksheet 4); in Italy, the "enemies of the State" tried by the Special Court.

III.1 Hegemonic ambitions of totalitarian regimes

War was not an accident of totalitarian policy but one of its core values

The question of this part is why the recourse to war was so fundamental to these regimes' beliefs and to their hegemonic ambitions. The answer lies in the ideologies themselves: fascism glorified war as the supreme test of a people, Nazism made the conquest of living space a condition of the race's survival, and Japanese militarism presented expansion as a mission. Aggression abroad was the logical extension of the regimes built at home.

EXAMPLE M. Ros opens this part with Hitler entering Vienna after the Anschluss, on 12 March 1938 — the image of a regime fulfilling abroad the programme it had announced since Mein Kampf in 1925.

Case study 1 — Abyssinia: Mussolini used Rome's past to justify a new empire

Fascist ideology made war a core value, and this led Italy into an aggressive foreign policy. Mussolini drew on the Roman Empire to justify his personal and international ambitions. He completed the brutal colonisation of Libya, begun with the Italo-Turkish war of 1911–1912, then attacked Abyssinia (Ethiopia), one of only two independent states left in Africa. The pattern — an ideological justification, then an invasion — recurred throughout the 1930s.

> **EXAMPLE** Mussolini funded the historical film Scipione l'africano (1937), on Rome's victory over Hannibal, as propaganda for fascist ambitions in Africa. Italy invaded Ethiopia in October 1935 and its troops entered Addis Ababa in May 1936.

Abyssinia exposed both Italy's real weakness and the League's powerlessness

In Europe Italy remained a power of lower rank: its empire was weak, poorly administered and in no way comparable to the British and French empires. Yet the conquest of Abyssinia showed that the League of Nations was ineffective whenever its decisions were not supported by the great powers. The League played for time, debating sanctions for seven months while the war went on.

> **EXAMPLE** The League pondered the question of sanctions from October 1935 to May 1936 — exactly the time it took Italy to conquer the country. The sanctions finally voted excluded oil, the one product that could have stopped the Italian army.

Lebensraum (key term): the theory that a nation needs its own territory and resources to survive

The concept of Lebensraum, "living space", was the backbone of the Nazi worldview and drove its foreign policy. It came from the German geographer Friedrich Ratzel, for whom nations had to be self-sufficient in resources and territory — what is called autarky — to protect themselves from external threats. The Nazis turned a geographical theory into a programme of conquest.

> **EXAMPLE** Ratzel formulated the idea in 1901. As early as 1919 Heinrich Himmler, the future head of the SS, wrote in his diary that he would some day "live my life in the east and fight my battles as a German far from beautiful Germany".

Mein Kampf turned living space into a plan: conquer the East, enslave the Slavs

Hitler devoted a whole chapter of Mein Kampf, "Eastern Policy", to this goal. He was committed to expanding Germany into the Slavic nations, settling Germans there as a master race, deporting most Russians to Siberia and using the rest as slave labour. The idea was not new — the push eastwards had been a motto of nineteenth-century German nationalism — but Hitler made it the centre of state policy.

> **EXAMPLE** Mein Kampf (1925) announced "an eastern policy in the sense of acquiring the necessary soil for our German people". The old nationalist motto was Drang nach Osten, the "drive to the East".

Japanese imperialism had an economic dimension: autarky in a world closing its markets

The Great Depression of 1929 hit Japanese trade and led to a desire for economic autarky in the 1930s. Expansion answered the needs of a growing population and of an industry short of raw materials and space. Conquest was presented as the solution to a crisis that the closing of world markets had made more acute.

> **EXAMPLE** Japan occupied Manchuria from 1931 for its rich grain fields and its reserves of raw minerals — the economic motive in its plainest form.

… and a racial dimension: Japan as the "superior race" destined to lead Asia

Japanese imperialism was fuelled by a strong sense of racial superiority. Through Pan-Asianism, Japan claimed that as a superior Asian race it had to liberate Asian territories from Western imperialism and build a "New Order in East Asia". Behind this lay resentment: despite its growing industrial and military power in the Pacific, Japan felt despised by the Western powers. Militarism grew together with a strong nationalism.

> **EXAMPLE** At the Paris Peace Conference in April 1919, the Western powers rejected the racial equality clause proposed by Japan — although Japan received Germany's Pacific islands as League mandates in 1920. The Emperor Hirohito was pictured in military uniform, and the rising-sun flag was the ensign of the Imperial Navy.

Case study 2 — Nanjing: aggression grew because nobody stopped it

Japan increased its aggressive policies after the staged Mukden incident of 1931, which served as a pretext to invade Manchuria. The League sent the Lytton Commission; Japan simply left the League. The Japanese understood that the United States would not respond militarily, and they took advantage of the civil war in China between Chiang Kai-shek's nationalists, the Kuomintang, and Mao Zedong's communists. In 1937 they attacked the rest of China.

> **EXAMPLE** In December 1937 a Japanese newspaper reported a "contest to kill 100 people using a sword" between two second lieutenants, under the headline "Incredible Record — Mukai 106, Noda 105". Japan had left the League in 1933.

Nanjing announced the features of the Second World War

The Rape of Nanjing, in December 1937 and January 1938, is a case study because it concentrates what the world war would become: a violent and racist ideology, expansionism and militarism, a sharp increase in the level of violence, and the inclusion of civilians among the military objectives. It is one reason why historians date the beginning of the war to 1937 rather than 1939, as Chapter 3 explains.

> **EXAMPLE** Estimates of the number of Chinese civilians and prisoners killed range from about 200,000 (the Tokyo war crimes tribunal) to 300,000 (the figure retained by China) — a debate in itself, still politically sensitive between the two countries.

III.2 Democracies unable to stop totalitarian regimes

A divided Europe, and a League that saw, heard and said nothing

In the 1930s Europe was divided between democracies (France, Britain), dictatorships (Germany, Italy, with Japan in Asia) and the USSR, a vast and isolated totalitarian regime. The League of Nations, the institution meant to stop aggression, proved unable to act whenever the great powers would not back it — and the British cartoonist David Low made that failure his subject.

> **EXAMPLE** Low's cartoon "On the Throne of Justice" (Evening Standard, 24 July 1935) shows three monkeys labelled "Abyssinia" seated on the throne of International Law, covering their eyes, ears and mouth: see no Abyssinia, hear no Abyssinia, speak no Abyssinia.

American isolationism kept the strongest democracy out of Europe's crises

In the United States, Roosevelt's efforts to break with isolationism were limited by Congress, which passed several Neutrality Acts in the 1930s forbidding arms sales and loans to countries at war. Note on the course: M. Ros's slide speaks of a "Republican Congress"; in fact the Democrats held the majority from 1935 to 1939, and isolationism ran across both parties — "an isolationist Congress" is the safer formulation in an essay.

> **EXAMPLE** Neutrality Acts were passed in 1935, 1936 and 1937. Roosevelt's telegram to Hitler and Mussolini of 14 April 1939 (DBQ 2 below) shows the limit of what he could do: ask for assurances, without any means of constraint.

The Stresa Front: Britain and France tried to keep Italy on their side against Germany

In 1935 Britain and France tried to build a "Stresa Front" with Italy against German ambitions. This calculation weighed on everything that followed: to keep Mussolini away from Hitler, London and Paris were reluctant to punish him over Abyssinia. The front collapsed anyway, and Italy turned towards Germany.

> **EXAMPLE** The Stresa conference was held in April 1935. Two months later Britain signed a naval agreement with Germany on its own, without consulting its Stresa partners.

Germany broke the Treaty of Versailles openly, by massive rearmament

From 1935 Germany repeatedly broke the terms of Versailles. It rearmed on a massive scale and created a unified armed force, the Wehrmacht, made up of the army (Heer), the navy (Kriegsmarine) and the air force (Luftwaffe). Hitler was preparing the conquest of his Lebensraum, and each breach that went unpunished made the next one easier.

> **EXAMPLE** The Wehrmacht was created in 1935, and the Anglo-German Naval Agreement of June 1935 allowed the Kriegsmarine to reach 35% of the Royal Navy's tonnage — Britain itself legalising a breach of Versailles.

Case study 3 — Appeasement (key term): accepting the aggressors' demands in order to avoid war

Appeasement refers to the efforts of the British prime minister Neville Chamberlain, from 1937, and of his French counterpart Édouard Daladier to avoid war by accepting the demands of the Axis powers. In doing so the democracies abandoned the goals they had set themselves in 1919: Germany, Italy and Japan were not halted, although their militarism openly contradicted the peace settlement.

> **EXAMPLE** Three examples in the course: the Anglo-German Naval Agreement of 1935; Britain's refusal in 1935 of an oil embargo that would have stopped Mussolini in Ethiopia; and France and Britain's decision not to intervene when Hitler sent troops into the demilitarised Rhineland in March 1936.

Discredited today, appeasement was popular and seemed pragmatic at the time

Appeasement is now widely seen as a policy of weakness, but it had solid reasons. Both countries remembered the slaughter of 1914–1918 and were deeply pacifist; Britain feared that the Commonwealth would not follow a second time; it was busy policing its empire and could not afford a major rearmament; many Britons felt Germany had been treated unfairly in 1919; both countries ranked their own economic problems higher; they felt unprotected by American isolationism; and many feared communism more than fascism.

> **EXAMPLE** The course gives Canada as the dominion whose support Britain could not take for granted, and India as the empire it had to keep policing. And in February 1933 the Oxford Union had voted that it would "in no circumstances fight for its King and Country" — the pacifism on which appeasement rested.

Munich, 1938: the democracies gave Hitler the Sudetenland without asking the Czechs

Hitler demanded the Sudetenland, the German-speaking region of Czechoslovakia — the only democracy left in central Europe — and threatened to invade the whole country. At the Munich conference, Mussolini posed as a moderate working for peace while helping Germany obtain what it wanted. The Czechs were not invited. Britain and Germany promised not to go to war, and Hitler promised he would never threaten the rest of Czechoslovakia.

> **EXAMPLE** The conference was held on 29–30 September 1938 between Hitler, Chamberlain, Daladier and Mussolini; the Sudetenland counted about 3 million German speakers. David Low's cartoon of 10 October 1938, "Europe can look forward to a Christmas of Peace", draws Hitler as Krampus, the demon who terrorises children at Christmas.

III.3 The road to WWII

The Axis: an alliance of interest between two dictators who distrusted each other

On his road to war Hitler needed allies, and he found one in Mussolini despite a certain mutual disdain. Nazism had been inspired by Fascism and Hitler had long admired Mussolini's regime; Mussolini, for his part, saw Hitler as an ambitious and pretentious rival. But Italy was economically too weak to face the democracies alone, and Mussolini needed German support.

> **EXAMPLE** The Axis was declared on 25 October 1936. In 1932 Mussolini had mocked Nazi racism: "racism is blondes' stuff!". The alliance was formalised by the Pact of Steel in 1939, and Japan joined in 1940.

Spain, 1936: the dictators intervened, the democracies stayed out

When civil war broke out in Spain in 1936, Germany and Italy supported General Franco's nationalists, and Germany used the conflict to test its air force. France and Britain did not intervene to help the Spanish Republic. The war became a rehearsal of the coming conflict — and a further proof that the democracies would not act.

> **EXAMPLE** Complementary example, not in the lesson: on 26 April 1937 the German Condor Legion bombed the Basque town of Guernica, a raid Picasso turned into his painting the same year.

The Rhineland, 1936: Hitler's calculated gamble paid off

The reoccupation of the demilitarised Rhineland was a calculated risk. German troops were not strong enough to resist the French army if France reacted, and they were under strict orders to retreat if it did. But France and Britain were not keen to fight Germany, so there was no resistance. Hitler's gamble paid off — and it taught him that the democracies would yield.

> **EXAMPLE** German troops entered the Rhineland on 7 March 1936. David Low's cartoon "Stepping Stones to Glory" (1936) draws Hitler climbing towards his goals on the bent backs of the democracies' leaders — the animation below follows those steps to 1939.

The Anschluss, 1938: Austria annexed by pressure, then ratified by a controlled vote

Hitler bullied the Austrian chancellor, Schuschnigg, in repeated speeches and moved troops to the border, threatening to invade unless he resigned in favour of a Nazi, Seyss-Inquart. Seyss-Inquart became chancellor and invited German troops into Austria. Hitler had broken Versailles once again, and Britain and France did nothing. A referendum then endorsed the annexation — from which opponents and Jews were excluded.

> **EXAMPLE** The German army entered Vienna on 12 March 1938. Political enemies and Jewish Austrians — 8% of the population — were not allowed to vote in the plebiscite, and the result was 99% yes.

Prague, March 1939: Hitler's lie ended appeasement

Appeasement ended when Hitler proved that he had lied at Munich, by invading the rest of Czechoslovakia in March 1939. This time the conquest could not be presented as uniting Germans: it was the occupation of a foreign people. Britain and France changed course and pledged to protect Romania, Greece and Poland should they be attacked by Germany or Italy.

> **EXAMPLE** Germany occupied Prague on 15 March 1939; the Franco-British guarantee to Poland followed on 31 March 1939 — the commitment that would bring both countries into the war five months later.

The Nazi-Soviet pact: two enemies agreed to divide Poland

In August 1939 Germany secured a non-aggression pact with the USSR, whose secret terms planned the division of Poland between them. For Hitler it removed the threat of a war on two fronts; for Stalin, whose army had just been gutted by the purges, it bought time and territory. Ideological enemies made a deal of pure interest — and the attack on Poland could begin.

> **EXAMPLE** The pact was signed on 23 August 1939. M. Ros's cartoon gives Stalin the line "I am not ready for war! I just killed 700,000 of my finest officers and communist leaders!" Germany attacked Poland, France's ally, on 1 September 1939; France and Britain declared war on 3 September.

The consequence of appeasement: each unpunished aggression prepared the next

Taken together, the events of the 1930s form a chain: the Axis powers left the League, invaded, remilitarised and annexed, and each time the absence of reaction encouraged the next step. Totalitarian ideology supplied the will to expand; the democracies' reluctance supplied the opportunity. That pairing is the answer to the chapter's key issue: the role of totalitarianism in the collapse of global peace in the late 1930s.

> **EXAMPLE** The chain in the course: 1933 Germany and Japan leave the League; 1935 Italy invades Ethiopia; 1936 the Rhineland and Spain; 1937 Japan invades southern China and Italy leaves the League; 1938 the Anschluss and Munich; March 1939 Prague; 1 September 1939 Poland.

Key figures

Hannah Arendt
German American political theorist (1906–1975); The Origins of Totalitarianism (1951)

George Mosse
German-American historian (1918–1999) who coined “brutalisation”; WW1 as the “matrix of totalitarianism”

A. J. P. Taylor
The Origins of the Second World War (1961): blame on the democracies' failure — a very controversial thesis

Jay Winter
Historian of a single “thirty years' war”, 1914–1945

Paul N. Hehn
Historian (1927–2014) for whom the Second World War was an economic conflict

Nicholas II
Last Tsar of Russia, forced to abdicate in February 1917

Lenin and Trotsky
Bolshevik leaders of the October 1917 coup; Trotsky led the Red Army in the civil war

Giovanni Gentile
Philosopher, co-author with Mussolini of the Doctrine of Fascism (1932)

Benito Mussolini
Leader of the Blackshirts, Prime Minister in 1922, the Duce of a totalitarian State from 1925

Gabriele D'Annunzio
Nationalist poet who seized Fiume in 1919; a model for fascist rituals

Giacomo Matteotti
Socialist deputy who criticised Mussolini; murdered in 1924

Victor Emmanuel III
King of Italy; refused martial law and appointed Mussolini in October 1922

Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht
Leaders of the Spartacist revolt, murdered in January 1919

Paul von Hindenburg
Field marshal and monarchist, President of the Republic; appointed Hitler Chancellor in 1933

Adolf Hitler
Leader of the NSDAP, Chancellor on 30 January 1933

Joseph Stalin
Soviet leader of the Five-Year Plan (1928) and of forced collectivisation; his speech of 7 January 1933 is Worksheet 2, source 1

Nicolas Werth
Historian of the Ukrainian famine of 1932–33 (Worksheet 2, source 4)

Heinrich Himmler
Head of both the Gestapo and the S.S. — the fusion of party and state police

Nikolai Yezhov
Head of the NKVD during the Great Purge; executed in 1940 and erased from photographs

Leni Riefenstahl
Film director of Triumph of the Will, shot at the 1934 Nuremberg rally

Alexei Stakhanov
Soviet miner turned into the model of the worker-hero in 1935

Neville Chamberlain
British prime minister from 1937, architect of appeasement and of Munich

Édouard Daladier
French prime minister who signed the Munich Agreement

Friedrich Ratzel
German geographer who formulated the theory of Lebensraum (1901)

David Low
British cartoonist of the Evening Standard, critic of appeasement

Numbers

≈ 20,000
Blackshirts who marched on Rome in October 1922, according to the class

2.6% → 37.4%
NSDAP vote, May 1928 → July 1932 (33.1% in November 1932)

5.6 million
Unemployed in Germany in 1932

7% → 90%
Share of Soviet peasant households collectivised, 1928 → 1936 (Worksheet 2)

8 acres
About 3.2 hectares: the land that officially made a peasant a kulak

32% · 22%
Share of the monthly grain target reached in Ukraine in September 1932 and by 25 October 1932

≈ 70,000
Disabled Germans killed by the T4 doctors, 1939–1941, mostly in gas chambers (M. Ros's slides)

680,000
Executions during the Great Purge of 1937–38

400,000
Germans forcibly sterilised, 1933–1945

85
People murdered in the Night of the Long Knives, 1934

35%
Kriegsmarine tonnage allowed relative to the Royal Navy (1935)

3 million
German speakers in the Sudetenland (1938)

99%
“Yes” in the Austrian plebiscite, with opponents and Jews excluded

Vocabulary

DEFINING THE REGIMES

totalitarianism
A regime that strives to impose total control on society through coercion, in order to transform man according to an ideology. Key Term of the chapter.

ideology
A set of beliefs that sets a supreme goal to be achieved.

New Man
The human being a totalitarian regime wants to create, remade by its ideology.

propaganda
The organised spreading of ideas and images to win or control opinion; for Arendt, marked by contempt for facts.

dictatorship
A regime where one person or party holds power without legal limits or free elections.

Fascism
Mussolini's ideology and regime: the nation and the absolute State above individuals and classes.

Nazism
Hitler's ideology and regime, founded on race struggle, racial purity and expansion.

Stalinism
Stalin's regime in the USSR: Marxist class struggle imposed through planning, collectivisation and terror.

key traits of totalitarianism
Ideology, dynamic leader, one-party rule, state control of individuals and society, methods of enforcement, modern technology.

THE LEGACY OF THE WAR

brutalisation
George Mosse's concept: the violence of the First World War carried into post-war societies and politics.

mutilated victory
Italian nationalists' name for a victory in 1918 that did not bring the territory they expected.

Diktat
A dictated peace: the German name for the Treaty of Versailles, imposed without negotiation.

stab-in-the-back myth
The false claim that the German army was not defeated in 1918 but betrayed at home.

Spartacists
German revolutionary communists led by Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht; their revolt was crushed in January 1919.

Bolsheviks
Lenin's revolutionary Marxists, who seized power in Russia in October 1917.

irredentism
The demand to annex territories considered national but left outside the state; in Italy after 1919.

Biennio Rosso
The “red years” 1919–1920 in Italy: land seizures, strikes and factory occupations.

soviet
A workers' council in factories or the countryside; the Bolsheviks seized power with their support in 1917.

Red Scare
The fear of communist revolution that the Russian Revolution spread in Europe.

War Guilt Clause
The clause of the Treaty of Versailles making Germany responsible for the war.

Weimar Republic
The German democracy established in 1918–1919 after the fall of the Empire.

SEIZING POWER

Blackshirts / squadristi
Fascist squads that attacked socialists and peasant leagues, often paid by landowners.

March on Rome
The Blackshirts' march of October 1922 that pushed the king to appoint Mussolini.

Duce / Führer
“Leader”: the titles of Mussolini and Hitler.

SA (Sturmabteilung)
The Nazi storm troopers: a mass street force.

SS (Schutzstaffel)
The Nazi elite guard, more selective than the SA.

Reichstag
The German Parliament; set on fire on 27 February 1933.

swastika
An ancient good-luck sign adopted as the Nazi emblem in 1920.

fasces
An ancient Roman bundle of rods around an axe, emblem that gave Fascism its name.

Mein Kampf
Hitler's book (1924–1925) setting out his racist programme and ambitions.

Munich coup (1923)
Hitler's failed attempt to seize power by force in November 1923.

FASCIST ITALY

fascistissime laws
Laws of 1925–26 that banned opposition parties and ended parliamentary rule in Italy.

parliamentary monarchy
A monarchy where the government answers to an elected Parliament; ended in Italy by Mussolini.

Lateran Accords
1929 agreements between Mussolini and the Pope creating the Vatican City State.

racial laws
Italy's anti-Semitic laws of 1938, passed after the alliance with Hitler.

Fascist Era
The regime's calendar, counting 1922 as Year I.

Opera Nazionale Balilla (ONB)
The Italian Fascist youth organisation.

Doctrine of Fascism
Text of 1932 by Mussolini and Gentile defining Fascism as totalitarian.

parliamentarism
Government by elected assemblies, rejected by Fascism.

concordat
A treaty between a state and the Pope; Mussolini's with the Vatican in 1929.

STALIN'S USSR

class struggle
In Marxism, history as a conflict between social classes, meant to end in a classless society.

Five-Year Plan
Stalin's economic plan from 1928: fixed targets for industry and agriculture over five years.

collectivisation
The forced merging of private farms into collective or state farms.

kolkhoz / kolkhoznik
A collective farm / a member of one.

sovkhoz
A state-owned farm.

kulak
Officially a peasant owning over 8 acres (3.2 ha); in practice any peasant who refused collectivisation.

Holodomor
The man-made famine of 1932–33 in Ukraine.

OGPU
The Soviet political police in the early 1930s, used to seize grain.

autarky / self-sufficiency
An economy that aims to depend on no one else.

NAZI GERMANY

race struggle
The Nazi belief that history is a permanent war between races.

racial purity
The Nazi aim of keeping the “race” free of any mixing.

anti-Semitism
Hostility to and persecution of Jews.

Aktion T4
The Nazi programme of murdering disabled people, from 1939.

Lebensraum
“Living space”: the land the Nazis wanted to conquer in the East for the German race.

Aryan
In Nazi ideology, the supposedly purest race, at the top of a hierarchy of races.

hierarchy of races
The Nazi belief that some races are more “valuable” than others.

CONTROLLING SOCIETY

cult of personality
Systematic glorification of the leader, presented as the embodiment of the nation.

propaganda
Controlled information designed to shape opinion rather than to inform it.

censorship
Suppression of anything that contradicts the regime — up to the retouching of photographs.

“New Man”
The model human being each ideology claims to produce: a race, a worker, a servant of the Party.

Hitler Youth
Nazi youth organisation, compulsory from 10 to 18; Italy had the Balilla, the USSR the Komsomol.

Stakhanovism
Soviet cult of the record-breaking worker, named after the miner Stakhanov (1935).

Nuremberg laws (1935)
Laws forbidding marriage and relations between Jews and “persons of German blood”, and defining citizenship by descent.

eugenics
Doctrine aiming to “improve” a population by preventing the reproduction of those judged unfit.

socialist realism
Official Soviet art showing idealised communist values, such as the emancipation of the proletariat.

MASS TERROR

political police
Police answering to the leader or the party rather than to the courts: OVRA, Gestapo, NKVD.

show trial
A trial staged for the public, where the verdict is decided in advance and the accused confess.

Great Purge (1937–38)
Stalinist repression that decimated the party and the army: 680,000 executions.

Gulag
The Soviet system of labour camps, spread across the country and used as a workforce.

concentration camp
Place of confinement outside the law; Dachau opened in 1933, prisoners sorted by coloured triangles.

Night of the Long Knives (1934)
Nazi purge of its own paramilitary leadership: 85 people murdered.

State Defence Law (1926)
Italian law restoring the death penalty and creating a Special Court for the “enemies of the State”.

THE ROAD TO WAR

Lebensraum
“Living space”: Ratzel's theory (1901), made by Hitler the goal of conquering the East (key term).

autarky
Economic self-sufficiency in resources and territory, pursued by Germany, Italy and Japan.

Drang nach Osten
“Drive to the East”: motto of nineteenth-century German nationalism, revived by Nazism.

Pan-Asianism
Japanese claim to liberate Asia from Western imperialism under Japanese leadership.

Rape of Nanjing
Massacre of Chinese civilians and prisoners by the Japanese army, Dec. 1937–Jan. 1938.

Stresa Front
Franco-British-Italian attempt (April 1935) to contain German ambitions.

Wehrmacht
The German armed forces created in 1935: Heer, Kriegsmarine and Luftwaffe.

Munich Agreement
Sept. 1938: Britain, France and Italy hand the Sudetenland to Hitler, without the Czechs.

Anschluss
Germany's annexation of Austria, March 1938, ratified by a plebiscite (99% yes).

Axis
Alliance of Germany and Italy (Oct. 1936), the Pact of Steel (1939), joined by Japan (1940).

Nazi-Soviet pact
Non-aggression pact of 23 August 1939, with a secret plan to divide Poland.